treachery? What wrong did I do? Why me? There were no answers; and I did not try too hard to find them. At least not now.

I got into the police jeep. Just when the vehicle was to move forward, a group of photographers rushed in, clicking furiously. I requested the driver to stop the vehicle.

'Let everyone get a good photograph of mine. Everyone should be satisfied,' I said.

Among the photographers was Babu, a friend of mine. His click made it to the cover page of *India Today* magazine. And I became the iconic face of the ISRO spy case. Babu came to me after my release, and apologised profusely.

'You were just doing your job,' I told him. 'And you did it quite well.'

I was in police custody now, which meant they were going to interrogate me. I did not know where they were taking me, but the route was familiar to me as I had lived most of my life in Trivandrum. From Vanchiyoor Police Station, the van moved to Pattoor, took a turn to the right, up to the General Hospital junction and then to Vazhuthakaud. Finally we arrived at the Latex Guest House in Poojapura. This place would be my residence for four days when I would be tortured by a group of Intelligence Bureau officials with a fictitious story outline they had no idea how to fill in.

INTO THE BAGASSE PIT

Without the right partner, a game of bridge and rocket science can end with some very bad blood.

Friends told me in half jest that I had the sweetest job offer when Parry & Co. advertised for a trainee assistant engineer for its facility, Deccan Sugars & Abkari Company in Trichy. I applied, and the job was mine. The company made a deal: I will be designated trainee assistant engineer for three years with a monthly stipend of Rs 300 for the first year, Rs 400 for